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Social media as a destination marketing tool: its use by national tourism organisations

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Social media are gaining prominence as an element of destination marketing organisation (DMO) marketing strategy at a time when public sector cuts in their funding are requiring them to seek greater value in the way marketing budgets are spent. Social media offers DMOs with a tool to reach a global audience with limited resources. The aim of this study is to explore the usage of social media among the DMOs of the top 10 most visited countries by international tourists. The study uses content analysis and semi-structured interviews to examine the usage and impact of social media marketing strategies and identifies a framework of best practice for other national tourism organizations (NTOs) to learn from. The study argues that social media usage among top DMOs is still largely experimental and that strategies vary significantly.

Keywords: DMOs; social media; Twitter; School of Tourism

Introduction

The creation and accessibility of the Internet have fundamentally changed how travellers access information, the way they plan for and book trips, and the way they share their travel experiences (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Senecal & Nantel, 2004; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). One significant development in the evolution of the Internet is the increasing prevalence of social media platforms that enable Internet users to collaborate, communicate and publish original content such as blogs, videos, wikis, reviews, or photos (Boyd and Ellison, 2008). Social media websites, facilitate consumer-generated content (CGC), and are widely used by online travellers' (Gretzel, 2006; White & White, 2007). CGC and reviews sites such as Tripadvisor.com, are widespread and may even undermine the authority of traditional destination marketing organisations (DMOs) or conventional advertisements (Gretzel, 2006; Gretzel, Yuan, & Fesenmaier, 2000; Rand, 2006). This study seeks to understand how widespread the usage of social media is among marketing organisations of top international tourism destinations. More specifically, this study has four research objectives:

- (1) To explore why and how top national DMOs strategically employ social media to market their destinations.
- (2) To demonstrate the varying degree of usage of social media among top national DMOs.

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- (3) To determine what factors contribute to advanced level of social media activity.
- (4) To identify best practice examples from the use of social media by DMOs.

To meet these research objectives, this study reviews the social media literature and its use in tourism. The study then outlines the implications for DMOs and identifies best practice examples to enable effective use of social media in marketing destinations.

Social media and tourism

Social media are changing the way society consumes and contributes to the creation of information. Technology now allows individuals to easily contribute their thoughts, opinions and creations to the Internet. This has radically altered the way in which information is created and disseminated (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Gretzel et al., 2000; Senecal & Nantel, 2004; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Prior to Web 2.0, the Internet functioned solely in one direction – a ‘read-only’ format (Borges, 2009). Published information was static and interaction with other Internet users and/or publishers was basically non-existent. Web 2.0 propelled by user-generated content through social media and social network sites (Brake & Safko, 2009; Buhalis & Law, 2008). Schegg, Liebrich, Scaglione, and Ahmad (2008, p. 152) argue that the evolution of Web 1.0–2.0 marks a shift from ‘users rather than organizations taking charge [of the Internet]’. Thevenot (2007) shows that as social media rises in popularity, users gain more power as the authority of marketers and institutions declines. In relation to tourism, marketers and institutions no longer have ultimate control over the image of their destination or product. Web 2.0 facilitates the integration of the following five functional properties: information representation, collaboration, communication, interactivity, and transactions (Gretzel, Fesenmaier, Formica, & O’Leary, 2006, p. 147).

Social media are a current and constantly evolving phenomena involving CGC shared online (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2009; Stankov, Lazic, & Dragicevic, 2010; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Brake and Safko (2009), offer the following definition.

Social media refers to activities, practices, and behaviours among communities of people who gather online to share information, knowledge, and opinions using conversational media. Conversational media are Web-based applications that make it possible to create and easily transmit content in the form of words, pictures, videos, and audios. (p. 6)

Social media refers to ‘participatory’, ‘conversational’, and ‘fluid’ online communities (Qualman, 2009; Tuten, 2008) focused on user-generated content (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Buss & Strauss, 2009; Ruzic & Bilos, 2010; Schegg et al., 2008; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010).

Social media is particularly relevant since tourism is an ‘information-intensive industry’ (Gretzel et al., 2000, p. 147; Wang, Quaehee, & Fesenmaier, 2002). Consumers obtain information to assist in the trip-planning process and to make informed decisions about destinations, accommodation, restaurants, tours, and attractions (Chung & Buhalis, 2008; Ruzic & Bilos, 2010; Thevenot, 2007; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010). Tourism experiences cannot be evaluated prior to consumption as they are intangible; personal recommendations are very influential (Buhalis, 1998; Gretzel et al., 2000; Litvin, Goldsmith, & Pan, 2008). Travellers, rely on other travellers’ advice, versus guidebooks and standard print advertisements (Casalo, Flavian, & Guinaliu, 2010). As a result, travel companies such as Lonely Planet developed their own online travel communities to engage consumers in conversations. Wang et al. (2002, p. 407) affirm that these travel communities, will ‘gain importance in the future’. Chung and Buhalis (2008, p. 272) attribute the popularity of online travel

communities to the ability to gain trustworthy reviews. The line of communication is no longer limited to producer-to-consumer, but can be consumer-to-consumer, and consumer-to-producer, as well as many-to-one, one-to-many, one-to-one, or many-to-many (Buhalis, 2003). Accordingly, marketers are able to use social media to try to stimulate conversation, encourage interaction, and engage in ways that traditional marketing (Tuten, 2008). This involvement can be vital to developing loyalty, generating interesting content and increasing awareness (Parise, Guinan, & Weinberg, 2008). The advent of social media and the shift from Web 1.0 to Web 2.0 also marks the shift from word-of-mouth to what Qualman (2009) terms *world-of-mouth*. The importance of adopting social media practices in tourism marketing is critical (Gretzel et al., 2000; Hjalager, 2010; Ruzic & Bilos, 2010; Schegg et al., 2008).

DMOs and social media

Gretzel et al. (2006) highlighted future challenges for DMOs would face in the near future. The first challenge was adapting to technological change (Gretzel et al., 2006). DMOs have had websites and purchased online advertising for many years but the Internet evolved with the arrival of Web 2.0 and the rise of social media. Stankov et al. (2010, p. 112) argued that DMOs are 'beginning to realise the importance of using the power of social media', but through their content analysis, found that less than half of the 39 NTOs in the European Travel Commission were officially represented on Facebook. Marketing via social media seems to be what is most relevant to the way in which tourism is utilising social media.

Social media, tourism marketing and DMOs: the research problem

In the current economic climate of public austerity NTOs and more regionally and locally focused DMOs and tourism boards, are losing elements of their funding, offices and the ability to market as widely as they did previously. VisitBritain, for example, lost 34% of government funding in late 2010 and was forced to cut 70 jobs and close 14 overseas offices (Johnson, 2011). Many DMOs turn to social media as a relative low-cost and global reach marketing tool. In response to the budget cuts, Sandi Dawe, Chief Executive of VisitBritain asserted that:

We will use new technology including our award-winning suite of multi-lingual websites, social media platforms and international public relations expertise to maintain our global footprint, as well as a staffed presence in key locations. (Dawe, cited in The Independent, 2010)

Current campaigns and initiatives suggest that a limited number of tourism organisations are beginning to study social media and develop strategies to use it to their advantage. Tourism organisations that do not adopt social media will lack a competitive advantage (Schegg et al., 2008; Stankov et al., 2010; Wang et al., 2002). However, what could be more detrimental than not understanding or adopting social media practices is using such practices in a poor manner (Schegg et al., 2008; Wang et al., 2002).

Hence, a clear understanding of why and how social media function is vital to tourism destination marketing. One sizeable gap in the existing literature is research examining the use of social media by tourism DMOs. Little research has been conducted to study how tourism entities are evolving with the Internet and using social media to market destinations and engage with potential consumers. Consequently, there is a lack of understanding of social media platforms and usage related to tourism. Xiang and Gretzel (2010) echo this

fact noting that ‘the extent to which social media constitute the online tourism domain is not well understood in an objective, comprehensive way’.

Research methodology

This study is exploratory in nature and adopts an inductive approach seeking to explore the nature and degree of the usage of social media among tourism destinations. A comparative approach is adopted to understand social media use in a variety of countries’ DMOs to not only draw out similarities and differences, but also to ‘go beyond description toward the more fundamental goal of explanation’ (Hayne & Harrop, 1982, p. 7 cited in Pearce & Butler, 1993, p. 21). Comparative studies allow the subjects being researched to ‘transfer experiences and learn from others’ (Pearce & Butler, 1993, p. 32). The principal focus of this study is the analysis and interpretation of data collected from content analysis and semi-structured interviews with DMOs. The research utilises two methods to examine in what ways, and for what purposes, DMOs are employing social media to market their destinations. The research is complemented by the use of secondary sources (e.g. market intelligence and industry reports) to help benchmark performance and the activities of social media in DMO marketing. While quantitative research allows for statistical analysis, qualitative research allows for the collection of ‘relatively detailed information about relatively few cases’ (Veal, 2009, p. 99). By employing both quantitative and qualitative methods, this research seeks to gain a well-rounded analysis and understanding of the use of social media among national DMOs.

Quantitative research was chosen as the primary research method for this study to classify, measure and analyse how top national tourism authorities utilise social media to engage with consumers and market destinations. Quantitative analysis was chosen to incorporate as much data and scope of social media activity as possible. Content analysis was selected as the preferred research method as it allows one to ‘use a set of procedures to make valid inferences from text’ (Weber, 1990). Social media are relatively new, so the way and degree with which DMOs utilise social media as part of their marketing efforts vary considerably. Information, posts, tweets, blog entries, and other forms of content exist freely on the web, but due to the relative infancy of the technology, there is comparatively little research to assess, explain, or even examine these forms of marketing, advertising, and business-to-consumer interactions. A content analysis is the most appropriate research method since ‘the pursuit of content analysis is fundamentally empirical in orientation, exploratory, concerned with real phenomena, and predictive in intent’ (Krippendorff, 1980, p. 9). The content analysis in this study is used to ‘describe trends in communication content’ (Berelson, 1952, cited in Weber, 1990, p. 9).

When choosing which social media platforms to analyse for this study, Twitter and Facebook were selected because they have millions of users, a strong participation from companies and organisations, and differ widely in services, reach, and usage. Furthermore, when undertaking a pilot study in April–May 2011, it became clear that the most common social media platforms DMOs participated in were Facebook and Twitter (and less often, YouTube.) Therefore, in an effort to analyse as much data as possible from the DMOs on consistent platforms, Twitter and Facebook were selected.

Facebook, launched on 4 February 2004, has over 750 million active users, 50% of whom log on to the website daily (Facebook, 2011.) Businesses and organisations create and maintain an official presence on Facebook to engage with consumers.

Twitter is a micro-blogging website that was launched in 13 July 2006 (Jansen, Zhang, Sobel, & Chowdury, 2009). Via Twitter, users can send 140-character messages, called

'tweets', that answer the question 'What's happening?' (Schetzina, 2010b). Twitter is primarily about now, as it is excellent for current events and crisis communications. According to July 2011 statistics, with over 175 million users, Twitter is by far the most popular micro-blogging website. Whereas most 'friends' on Facebook have met off-line, it is common for users of Twitter to 'follow' accounts of those they have not met in real life, such as celebrities, bloggers, new organisations, comedians, or other personal users with whom they share similar interests (Ross et al., 2009 cited in Stankov et al., 2010). Organisations see Twitter as a new, groundbreaking way of reaching out to, interacting with, and understanding the consumer behaviour of millions around the world. Given its popularity, influence and usage by both consumers and businesses, Twitter was an important site to examine in this research.

Sampling process

The content analysis for this study analysed data from seven tourism boards' official Facebook pages and Twitter accounts. The countries were chosen according to the top 10 international tourism destinations as indicated by the United Nations World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) *Tourism Highlights 2010 Edition*. The rationale behind choosing the top 10 international destinations was that these destinations have well-established, national level DMOs in place, in most cases. These DMOs have been marketing their countries, and cities, regions, and attractions over a long time period and some have begun to adopt digital marketing strategies. Most DMOs have expanded their efforts to include adopting social media platforms as part of their marketing efforts.

The selection of countries, however, presented a few minor problems which were explored in the pilot study which evaluated the top 10 DMOs in terms of international arrivals. Firstly, though the United States is ranked in the top 10, there is no national tourism body for the entire country. The exception to the rule here was the selection of Tourism Queensland (with representation in London) as a particularly dynamic and active DMO in one state of Australia as its social media presence was identified in the pilot study as being worthy of more detailed investigation due to the contribution it could make to best practice. Secondly, no Facebook or Twitter activity could be found for two of the top 10 destinations – China and Italy. As both Twitter and Facebook are restricted in China, this was to be expected. In contrast, Italy did confirm their lack of social media marketing initiatives, but provided no explanation for this lack of participation. Finally, some tourism organisations operate multiple Twitter accounts and/or Facebook pages for each office. For example, Spain has a general Twitter account, operated from Madrid for all audiences as well as an account operated from the London office and geared specifically to those in the UK. Posts and tweets from 1 June to 30 June 2011 were analysed. It was hypothesised that the busy summer season would require increased marketing initiatives by DMOs and provide a large and diverse sample of social media content to analyse.

Content analysis can code words, word senses, sentences, or themes (Weber, 1990, p. 22). Due to the short nature of Facebook posts and 140-character limit to tweets, this study codes entire posts or tweets, usually between one to three sentences. To determine appropriate categories, several weeks were spent examining the Twitter feeds and Facebook pages of the top 10 DMOs during the pilot study to develop an understanding of the types of content, information, and engagement they were producing. This pilot study determined what categories would be relevant, and worth further investigation in the content analysis. On the basis of the pilot study, Table 1 was constructed which lists the categories used to

Table 1. List of categories for the content analysis.

Country
Social media outlet (Facebook or Twitter)
Handle
Are there tags (@s)?
How many people are tagged?
Who is tagged?
Are there hashtags (#s)?
What is the hash tag?
Are there RTs (Twitter) or Likes (Facebook)?
Are there comments (Facebook) or replies (Twitter)?
How many comments or replies?
Is the tweet/post interactive?
Does the tweet/post include other content?
Does it include a link to a website?
Does it include a photo?
Does it include a video?
Does it include audio?
Is the tweet/post customer service related?
Is it responding to criticism?
Is it responding to a compliment?
Is it thanking customers/travellers?
Is it requesting feedback from customers/travellers?
Is it responding to an enquiry?
Is the tweet/post promotion related?
Is it promoting an event?
Is it promoting a destination?
Is it promoting another website?
Is it promoting the DMOs official website?
Is it promoting an attraction, restaurant, or hotel?
Is it promoting a particular food?
Is it promoting another social media outlet of the DMO? Which one?
Is the tweet/post contest related?
Is it asking a trivia question?
Is it providing the answer to a trivia question?
Is it reminding users of an on-going contest?
Is it announcing winners of a trivia question or contest?
Does the tweet/post request user-generated content?
Is it requesting photos?
Is it requesting videos?
Is it requesting audio?
Does the tweet/post provide information?
Does it provide factual information? (e.g. dates of an event, location of an attraction)
Does it provide opinion or review? (e.g. top 10 best restaurants, the review of a play)
Is the tweet/post responding to something?
Is the post responding directly to another user?
Is the tweet a retweet?
Is it a retweet because the DMO was mentioned in a previous tweet?
Is it a retweet to share relevant information from another user?
General – the tweet/post does not fit any particular categories (e.g. Good morning!)
Is the post congratulatory?
Is it congratulating themselves (the destination)? (e.g. the destination won an award)
Is it congratulating others?
Has the information in the tweet/post or the tweet/post been posted previously (in the month of June 2011)?

code data. Categories were not mutually exclusive; any tweet or Facebook post could be classified in a variety of categories.

Through the content analysis of DMOs primary social media platforms (Twitter and Facebook) it is possible to provide an understanding of how these platforms are employed. However, the content analysis does not specifically examine the strategies employed to utilise social media. For these reasons, this study also used interviews as a second strand of research to contextualise and assist the understanding of NTO use of social media in a strategic marketing context.

One critical component of measuring the impact of social media as a marketing tool was the measurement of the number of replies to specific posts. This was easily tracked and analysed on Facebook, but not via Twitter. On Twitter, a general user is unable to view all replies sent to a particular user unless those replies are sent from users that the coder is following. For this reason, this study was unable to obtain an accurate number of comments that resulted from tweets. However, it is possible to track retweets – the term for the action when one user posts the verbatim message of another user, similar to the forwarding function in emails. Facebook offers a similar function where users can ‘like’ other members’ posts where a user actively expresses an engagement with the posting. Unfortunately until recently it was not possible to track the ‘share’ function on Facebook. Therefore, these two elements could serve as comparison in this study. Lastly, the categories defined in this particular content analysis permitted an analysis of how tourism organisations are using social media; for instance, the nature of the tweets and posts, frequency of those posts, and reason for the posts. The content analysis was also accompanied by a qualitative research process involving face to face semi-structured interviews.

Qualitative research provides complementary insights to quantitative research to gain an understanding about how DMOs social media strategies are spoken of and conceived versus how they are actually executed. Qualitative research proved particularly useful in understanding discrepancies between what the tourism-marketing professionals *believe* is happening and what is *actually* taking place. DMOs and Tourism Organisations were contacted via email and phone to find an employee in the most relevant department (typically in digital media or marketing). Six of the seven tourism boards analysed in the content analysis participated. Those included Visit Britain, Tour Spain, the German National Tourist Board, Visit Mexico, the Turkish Ministry of Tourism and Culture and the France Tourism Development Agency. The only tourism board with presence on Facebook and Twitter that did not agree to an interview was Tourism Malaysia. For reasons of employee anonymity, no names are disclosed – only the tourism organisation in view of the sensitivity of the subject matter. In addition a representative from the Public Relations agency that maintains the social media accounts for Tourism Queensland (Australia) was also interviewed. The rationale behind this was to provide insight and information from a DMO renowned for its marketing efforts and cutting-edge social media campaigns so an innovative industry leader could be used as a benchmark. All interviews were conducted in-person, at the London office of each tourism organisation and interviews lasted 1–1.5 hours. Interview questions were designed to gain additional insight that the content analysis could not provide, but also allowed room for the interviewee to contribute any information they deemed relevant to the use of social media to market tourism destinations.

Interviews were semi-structured and sought to gain an understanding of how and why certain social media initiatives are (or are not) chosen and implemented. A list of open-ended questions was formulated pertaining to this objective, though any additional, relevant information from the interviewee was accepted. During the interview, the researcher typed notes, or verbatim sentences, on a laptop. Seven interviews provided very detailed

Table 2. Questions for semi-structured interviews.

<i>Questions for semi-structured interviews</i>
1. When did the _____ Tourist Board begin implementing a social media strategy?
2. What social media tools are employed (Facebook, Twitter, a blog, etc.)?
3. Is the management and development of social media a separate role from other marketing employees at the France National Tourist Board?
4. How many people are responsible for maintaining a social media presence, developing strategies/campaigns, etc.?
5. What is the total budget dedicated towards social media? What percentage of the total marketing budget is this? How much is spent on, for example, TV or magazines (and how does that compare to what was spent in previous years)?
6. How much of the France National Tourist Board's budget is allocated to marketing?
7. How do social media and traditional media reinforce each other at the France National Tourist Board? Which is valued more?
8. What have been the biggest struggles related to incorporating social media into the France National Tourist Board's marketing strategy?
9. What has been the biggest social media success/failure?
10. How does the France National Tourist Board plan to develop social media in the future?
11. How do you measure successful social media efforts? ROI?
12. What makes marketing _____ as a destination different from other tourism boards?
13. To whom are most of the social media efforts directed (particular markets)? Are you using social media for particular markets?
14. What sorts of posts (Facebook, Twitter, etc.) do you think are the most effective? (e.g. do you think it helps to have a contest, ask a question, request photos, something general, advertising an event, etc.)
15. Do you have any particular strategies to gain followers on Twitter, 'likes' on Facebook?

information to enhance the results obtained from the content analysis. Table 2 presents the questions asked to all interviewees.

As with any interview process, the qualitative nature and politics of each organisation sometimes resulted in questionable validity, subjective opinions, or biased responses from interviewees. This though, is complemented by the content analysis, which attempts to provide a more objective analysis. Ultimately, the data gleaned from the interviews and the data collected from the content analysis combined to develop a comprehensive representation of the use of social media among the tourism organisations.

Findings and analysis

As shown in Table 3, the dates at which DMOs of the top 10 most visited international destinations established Twitter accounts varies. The earliest adopter, Malaysia, established a Twitter account in November 2008, yet Turkey did not establish an account until June 2011. The date at which each DMO joined Twitter does not directly correspond with the number of followers. While it might be argued that DMOs managing a Twitter account for a longer period of time would have more followers, this is not always the case. For instance, Germany established a Twitter account within days of Malaysia, but has over 50,000 fewer visitors. While some organisations actively manage and grow their social media endeavours, other organisations simply join but perhaps lack the support, knowledge, or interest to maintain the accounts effectively.

The dates at which the DMOs signed up for Twitter accounts are somewhat clustered. Three of seven of the DMOs joined in the autumn/winter of 2008. Table 4 describes the basic Facebook statistics for the selected DMO Facebook accounts. These figures demonstrate that, like the Twitter accounts, the date that the DMOs joined Facebook does not

Table 3. Basic Twitter statistics for the analysed DMOs, data collected 26 July 2011.

Country	Twitter handle	Followers	Following	Member since	Total no. of tweets	No. of tweets June 2011
Malaysia	@TourismMalaysia	53,270	64	12 November 2008	3769	70
UK	@VisitBritain	36,097	14,096	19 January 2009	6052	349
Spain	@spain	25,272	25,334	19 December 2008	871	23
Mexico	@WeVisitMexico	8034	3789	21 July 2009	1884	24
Germany	@GermanyTourism	2408	388	14 November 2008	620	33
France	@UK_Franceguide	1507	82	28 July 2009	1197	20
Turkey	@TurkeyTourismUK	64	183	20 June 2011	30	11
Italy	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a
China	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a

Table 4. Basic Facebook statistics for the analysed DMOs, data collected 26 July 2011.

Country	Facebook page	No. of likes	Member since	No. of posts June 2011
Spain	facebook.com/spain	425,863	November 2009	21
UK	facebook.com/LoveUK	415,609	December 2009	22
Malaysia	facebook.com/CutiCuti1Malaysia	76,332	May 2011	46
France	facebook.com/visitfrance	6271	February 2010	15
Mexico	facebook.com/WeVisitMexico	5966	July 2009	10
Germany	facebook.com/VisitGermany	6257	June 2008	17
Turkey	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a
Italy	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a
China	n/a	n/a	n/a	n/a

directly correspond with the number of Facebook fans often DMOs view joining and exhibiting a presence, no matter how inactive, on social media sites as more important than the actual maintenance of the site, the frequency with which they post, and the quality of the content distributed. Hay (2011, p. 10) postulates that businesses have to appear to be keeping up with the times – ‘to be seen to be in touch with *Zeitgeist*’. The sample of DMOs examined in this study confirms that social media is of interest to DMOs. The majority (seven) of DMOs maintain Twitter and/or Facebook accounts. Those that do not maintain Twitter and/or Facebook accounts are Italy and China. No explanations for the lack of use of social media by the Italian and Chinese Tourist Offices were acquired. However, it is assumed that the reason for no Facebook or Twitter use by the official China National Tourist Office is due to the fact that both websites are banned in China. The Turkish Ministry of Tourism and Culture is the only DMO of the seven with presence on Facebook and/or Twitter to not utilise *both* platforms. The Turkish Ministry of Tourism and Culture information officer explained that plans to launch a Facebook page were underway.

Social media strategies employed by NTOs

From the data analysed from the DMO posts, three main themes emerged: *post frequency*, *interaction*, and *content*. Twitter is centred on microblogging – short (mostly) textual.

Table 5. Average number of daily posts and total number of posts in June 2011.

Country	Average no. of daily Facebook posts, June 2011	Total no. of Facebook posts, June 2011	Average no. of daily tweet(s) June 2011	Total no. of tweet(s), June 2011
Mexico	0.33	10	0.8	24
Malaysia	1.53	46	2.33	70
Germany	0.57	17	1.1	33
UK	0.73	22	11.63	349
Turkey	n/a	n/a	0.37	11
France	0.5	15	0.67	20
Spain	0.7	21	0.77	23
Combined	0.73	131	2.52	530

Facebook, on the other hand, is much more multifaceted; users can upload pictures and videos to photo albums, communicate privately to other friends, and post information for their entire network to see. Both sites are pull based, as users choose a network of users from whom they wish to receive updates and can block other users or feeds any time. Table 5 shows that the average number of daily posts on Facebook is 0.73 compared to 2.52 daily Twitter posts a day. This aligns with the general public's use of the two platforms – 12% of Facebook users update their status each day, whereas 52% of users on Twitter post daily. Status updates are more integral to the purpose of Twitter, for businesses and individuals alike. While Twitter is driven by and excels at providing timely updates, Facebook is a good platform to employ to increase consumer loyalty.

There are different strategies being employed by NTOs. For example, VisitBritain cites consumer trust and engagement as the most important guiding factor to managing *Love UK*, VisitBritain's official Facebook account. 'If you update Facebook too much, you find that people are actually pulling out of it' explains the interviewee from the French Government Tourist Office in London'. According to the VisitBritain respondent loyalty to the consumer is much less of an issue on Twitter as they do not 'massively believe in Twitter' and think it is basically 'a lot of noise'. Conversely, the German National Tourist Board does not differentiate between the two platforms. Each message posted to Facebook is replicated on Twitter through applications used to integrate multiple social media platforms. Due to the constant status updates on Twitter, any given user's feed is constantly refreshing. Thus, many tweets get 'buried' very quickly. In fact, 92% of retweeting and replying to tweets occurs within one-hour of when the original tweet was posted. This suggests that after one-hour, very few people will view the tweet. Consequently, to ensure tweets will be viewed, it is almost crucial to update frequently and timing is of the essence. Hay (2011, p. 6) refers to this as the 'scatter gun approach'. On Twitter, businesses do not have very much information about their followers; instead, they bombard them with a variety of information hoping that something will be of interest due to low entry costs. The frequency with which each DMO posts to each individual platform also varies, and can be attributed to several factors and strategies. Figure 1 indicates that VisitBritain accounts for 66% of the total monthly tweets of the combined DMOs, clearly skewing the total number of tweets for all DMOs.

An important category of the content analysis was whether or not the analysed posts contained original information versus information that had been provided previously. Figure 2(a) and (b) represent the frequency with which VisitBritain publishes repeated content in comparison to the other DMOs. Of VisitBritain's 349 total tweets, only 52%

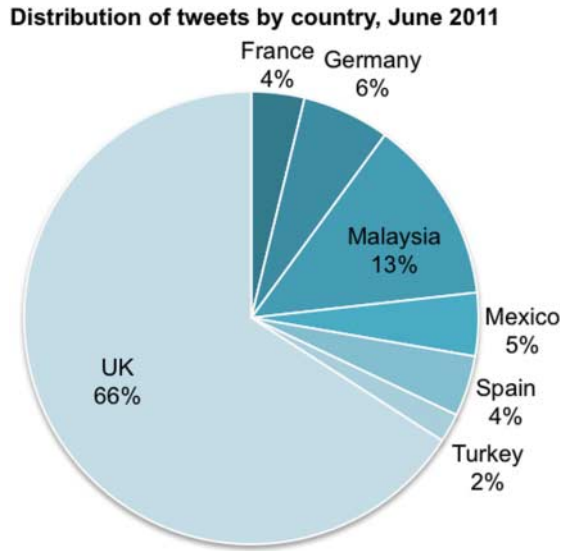


Figure 1. Distribution of tweets by country, June 2011.

provided original information. The other 48% of tweets were retweeted previous tweets or provided the same information as a previous tweet though not verbatim.

Figure 3(a) and (b) demonstrate that there is no general pattern of how many times the combined DMOs post per day. It is apparent that DMOs contribute much more often to Twitter, although some DMOs have more systematic strategies to how many times per day they post.

As Figure 4 shows, the Spanish National Tourist Office tweets roughly once a day. In contrast, VisitBritain's daily tweets were much less consistent, ranging from 1 to 29 per day. The frequency with which DMOs post and the overall total they post per month is only one important element of their social media strategies. Another key element is to what extent the DMOs use their social media platforms to interact and engage with their consumers.

Interaction with consumers

Gretzel et al. (2006, p. 118) argued that many DMOs view the Internet as a substitute for pre-existing technologies as 'Web sites have not *replaced* call centres, rather, Web presence often *drives* phone inquiries'. The Internet, and social media, are often additional tools to be used in conjunction with, not always as a replacement for, older strategies. Though most interviewees cited 'interaction' and 'engagement' and even 'informality' as the major benefits of utilising social media, the content analysis suggests a different pattern. While traditional marketing practices, such as advertising a specific event, can and do elicit responses via social media, social media allows much more than simply replicating other marketing strategies on a new technology. Facebook proclaims that their platform is about 'giving people the power to share and make the world more open and connected' (Facebook.com, 2011). However, this sort of sharing happens on a personal level. Interviewees suggested that organisations are often less comfortable with consumers voicing their opinions, criticisms and ideas, and frequently use the site to advertise and promote as they do in other forms of media. The study confirms that DMOs typically use social media, in

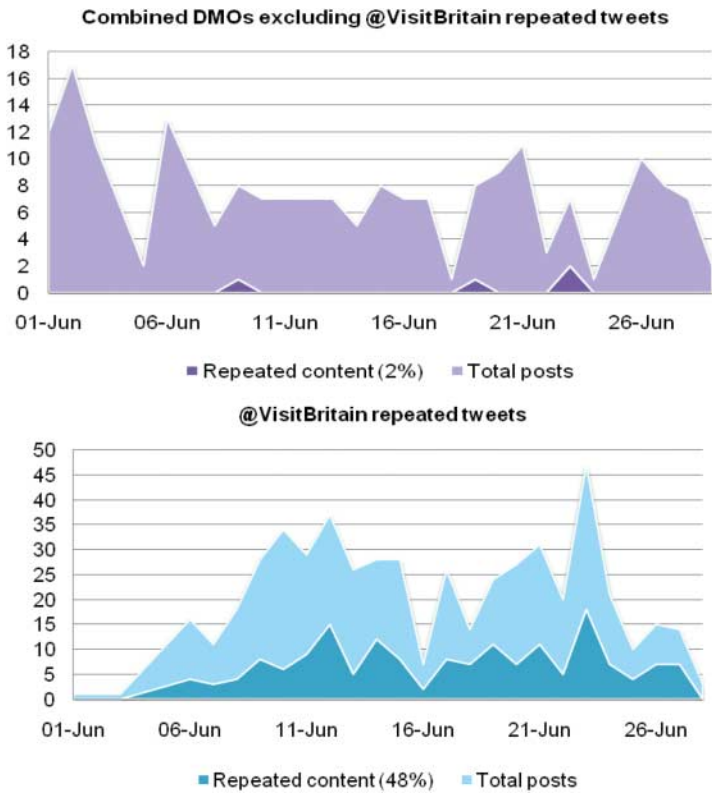


Figure 2. Distribution of repeated information by @VisitBritain on Twitter versus distribution of repeated information by all other DMOs combined.

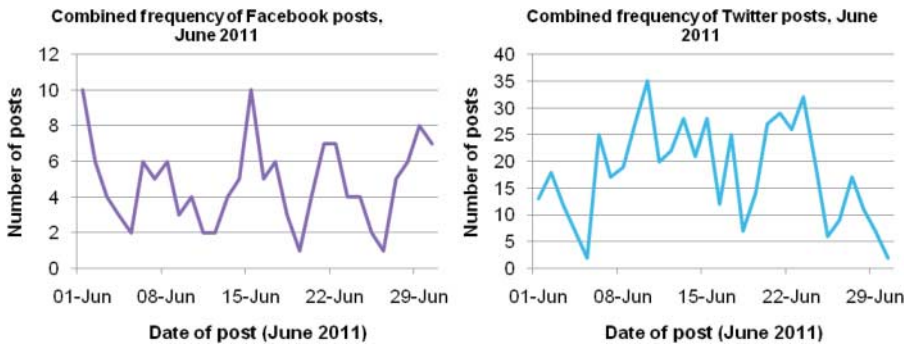


Figure 3. Frequency of Facebook and Twitter posts during the month of June 2011.

this case, Facebook and Twitter, to simply advertise and market via an additional medium, changing little about the content of the message. For example a tweet by the German National Tourist Board on 16 June 2011 (The Open Air Castle Festival), which advertises a weeklong festival in a German town illustrates this point. While there were multiple ways to advertise festivals and events before the advent of social media, this is a good example of using social media to implement traditional, pre-existing marketing methods. While Twitter

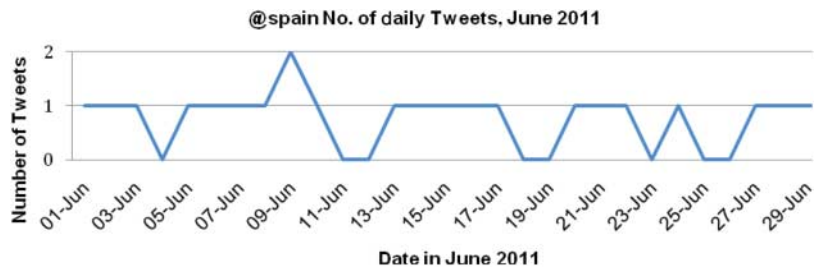


Figure 4. Number of daily Tweets from the @Spain Twitter account, June 2011.

followers of the @GermanyTourism account could easily reply to this tweet, it is not classified as ‘interactive’ for the purpose of this research. ‘Interactive’ was defined as a category for use in the content analysis as a post that directly asked a question or requested some form of response.

An interactive post by the German National Tourism Board (*We do like sausages. What about you? What is your favourite sausage?*) was deemed particularly successful by the respondent who explained that simple questions work well. This simple question: ‘*What’s your favourite German sausage?*’ garnered ‘more responses than anything else ever before’. Over the course of June 2011, some DMOs contributed considerably more interactive content than others. But across both platforms, the majority (88.2%) of posts were not interactive in nature.

Table 6 displays the degree of interactivity of each DMOs posts on Facebook and Twitter. DMOs, such as, the French and Spanish Tourism Boards, demonstrated similar levels of interactive posts on both platforms. Others, such as the British and Mexican tourism boards were much more interactive on Facebook than they were on Twitter. The only tourism board to have a higher percentage of interactive posts on Twitter than on Facebook was the Malaysian DMO. However, on both platforms the number of interactive posts was very few. There are a number of reasons to suggest that the level of each DMOs interactivity on Facebook versus Twitter is not coincidental, but strategic. Facebook allows the usage of media rich content that encourages users to *interact, like, comment, share, and engage*. In addition, Facebook allows fans to post their own experience and content on the organisation page and hence create a much stronger sense of community.

Table 6. Summary of interactive/non-interactive posts.

Country	Facebook			Twitter			Combined %
	Non-interactive	Interactive	%	Non-interactive	Interactive	%	
France	12	3	20%	16	4	20%	20%
Germany	22	4	15%	33	0	0%	7%
Malaysia	45	1	2%	67	3	4%	3%
Mexico	4	6	60%	21	3	13%	26%
Spain	9	12	57%	11	12	52%	55%
Turkey	0	0	n/a	11	0	0%	0%
UK	10	12	55%	330	19	5%	8%
Total	102	38	27%	489	41	8%	12%

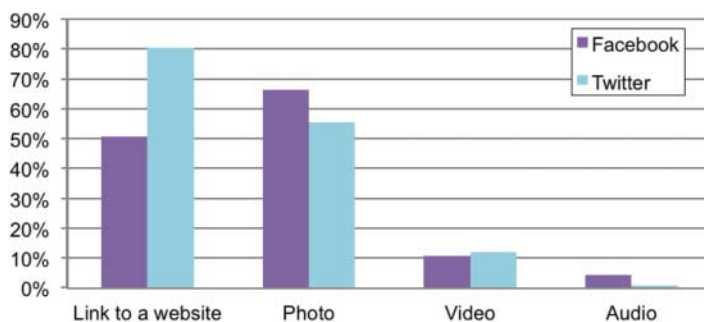


Figure 5. Distribution of type of content included in both Facebook and Twitter posts of the combined DMOs during June 2011.

Figures 5 and 6 demonstrate that postings on Facebook were over three times more interactive than updates on Twitter. This finding can be attributed to a number of factors including interactivity. As ‘interactivity’ is about the DMO *directly* posing a question or requesting feedback, content, or input from the audience, it is important to try to assess comments and responses. These are significantly easier to track and organise via Facebook than on Twitter. Twitter organises all ‘mentions’ (the nearest equivalent of a Facebook comment) in one pane. They are not, like Facebook, easily categorised by posting, but instead, by the time the comment was posted. For businesses, this complicates being able to easily comprehend and measure feedback. Furthermore, Twitter does not allow users to easily view comments from other users whom they do not follow. While the user to whom the comments are directed, in this case the DMO, can always view replies, other users will not be able to unless they are following the user who has replied. On Facebook, all users participating or viewing the post, regardless of whether or not the users are ‘friends’ with one another, can view comments. A retweet is the Twitter equivalent of forwarding an email- it simply re-posts information that has originated elsewhere previously.

Most DMOs interviewed mentioned the ability to measure consumer sentiment via social media. Almost 27% all posts from six tourism boards during the month of June on Facebook were categorised as interactive compared to 8% of their posts on Twitter reflects

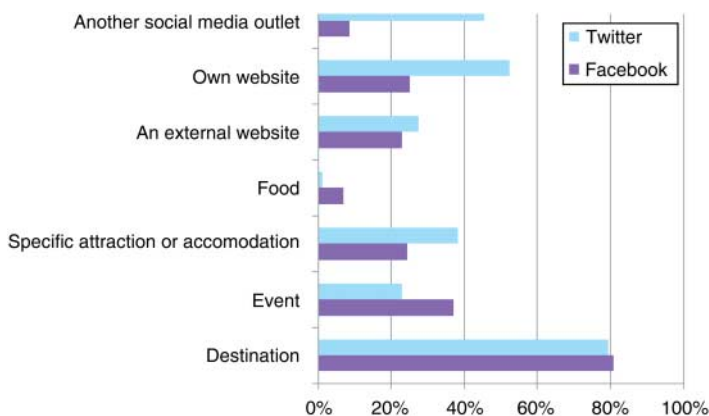


Figure 6. Type and distribution of promotional information in combined DMOs Twitter and Facebook posts, June 2011.

Table 7. Degree of consumer interaction with Facebook and Twitter posts.

	Facebook	Twitter
Average no. of 'likes' or retweets per post	269.6	4
% of posts 'liked' or retweeted	100%	74.3%
Average no. of comments per post	79.2	n/a
% of posts with comments	85.7%	n/a

the simplicity of Facebook's comment-tracking system. Every DMO with both a Facebook page and a Twitter account has more 'likes' on their Facebook page than followers subscribing to their Twitter updates. For instance, when the Spanish Tourism Board places a post on Facebook, it reaches over 15 times more people than an update posted on Twitter. Facebook reaches more people since given the frequency with which Twitter users update, each time a user logs in there are numerous updates (organised by the time in which they were posted) to scroll through whereas on Facebook, it is not uncommon to see all the updates from any given day. Even though the DMOs are communicating to a much larger audience when using Facebook, it is easier to interact with this audience given the lack of saturation of other postings and organisation of the commenting system. Using Facebook more than Twitter to engage consumers is a widely accepted strategy, as the respondent at Tourism Queensland observed that 'more people have a Facebook account than would engage in a daily Twitter feed'. DMOs use Facebook much more interactively because they understand how to measure and evaluate consumer's responses, inquiries, and criticisms. Interaction on Twitter is used more effectively for current content and for communication of what is happening now. After analysing 1.2 billion tweets, Sysomos, a social media analytics company, found that 71% of tweets are not retweeted nor replied to. When compared to Twitter, Facebook is a much more interactive social media platform, and the content from the DMOs confirms this.

Table 7 illustrates that across all DMOs, the average number of 'likes' (a way for a Facebook user to express interest in a post without writing a comment was 269.6. The average number of 'retweets', the only way to endorse a message and Twitter equivalent to a Facebook 'share', across all DMOs was only 4. Furthermore, every single Facebook post from a DMO had at least one 'like' attached to it. These findings demonstrate that regardless of the type of post (interactive or non-interactive in nature), users are still engaging with the information DMOs provide. The most prevalent form of this 'engagement' is the 'like' and the retweet, a simple act of approval that requires little involvement from the user. Though in interviews many representatives from DMOs cited social media's ability to encourage interaction and collaboration, these findings indicate that the DMOs are not necessarily utilising social media to their full potential in these areas.

Social media and DMOs

Wang et al. (2002, p. 14) argue that a virtual travel community should bring together 'a broad range of published content' and that the 'range, richness, reliability, and timeliness of information available to members [of these virtual communities] is likely to be far greater than that of any information available through more conventional means'. The majority of posts and tweets from DMOs included some form of other content, whether it was a photo, a link to a website, or a video which reinforced the range, richness and reliability Figure 5 summarises the type of content included in the combined DMOs

posts on Facebook and Twitter. It is therefore important for organisations to include as much rich content as possible, while providing the necessary information to their consumers.

The majority of all posts across both platforms contained some form of additional content – 81% of Facebook posts and 82% of Twitter posts included content. However, as the frequency with which the DMOs posted and the degree of interaction they displayed varied between Twitter and Facebook, so did the nature of the content included. Content came almost exclusively from the DMOs themselves, not other users. An example of using users' content on the Web is the fact that 95% of the images that stream on VisitBritain's home page come from the official VisitBritain account on Flickr.com, LOVEUK a photo-sharing social media platform. This Flickr account boasts 300 members who have contributed over 6000 photos, and according to the VisitBritain respondent, this saved VisitBritain over £200,000. Though Flickr is a natural choice for sharing photo-content, Facebook and Twitter could be used more often to share user content and create a stronger sense of collaboration and community. VisitBritain integrates their Flickr account with their Facebook account.

Posts often redirected users to another website. Eighty per cent of posts on Twitter included a link to an external website, while only 51% of Facebook updates included links to websites. The VisitBritain respondent argued that 'when users come to Facebook, they want to stay on Facebook'. In accordance with VisitBritain's strategy, only 5 of VisitBritain's 22 Facebook posts (23%) contained a link to an external website. Facebook is a much more complex platform than Twitter, allowing users to organise various types of multimedia, join pages, create an in-depth profile, and install third-party applications. Therefore, when users access the website, they tend to, and want to, stay on Facebook.com rather than browse other sites on the Internet. VisitBritain seeks to engage with their Facebook fans without bombarding them with information and links to external websites. A further reason that explains why the DMOs Twitter updates link to other websites over three times as often as Facebook updates can be attributed to Twitter's 140-character limit. Tweets cannot exceed this limit, so providing a hyperlink (which can be automatically shortened to contain less characters) allows the distribution of more information. While Facebook and Twitter enable the user to interact and converse with large groups of people, DMOs are still using these social media devices as promotional tools. This is reflected by 86% of all Facebook posts and 87% of all Twitter updates classified as promotion-related. Figure 6 depicts the type of promotional information DMOs included in their Twitter and Facebook posts and tweets. These categories were not mutually exclusive, and many updates promoted several things simultaneously. Nearly 80% of posts on either platform promoted the destination in some way, as the accounts analysed were from tourism boards- whose primary objective is to *market destinations*. In promoting destinations, events, attractions, or websites, it is also in the best interest of the DMOs to provide as much information as possible. Given the brevity of a Facebook or Twitter post, DMOs often linked to more information, or used the space to provide key pieces of information.

As a sub-category, information was classified in two ways: factual/historical information, or opinion/review. An example of factual or historical information is a tweet that provides dates and opening hours of a local festival, or information about the history behind a particular national holiday. Posts classified as opinion and review generally included information in 'Top 10' style lists, or a review of a hotel or attraction with 62% of Facebook posts containing information compared to 74% on Twitter. The majority of information posted was factual in nature. The amount of information classified as opinion or review is skewed by the quantity of reviews on the VisitBritain Super Blog. Occasionally, DMOs would use their Facebook account to encourage users to follow

their Twitter account, or vice versa. However, the representation in Figure 6 for how often Twitter was used to promote another social media outlet is skewed by some of the DMOs doing remarkably better than others. In addition to Facebook and Twitter accounts, VisitBritain manages an active blog, the VisitBritain Super Blog.

The '#' symbol (referred to as a 'hash tag') is used to organise posts and make them searchable. The Twitter account of the author of the post is also featured in the post, as several UK travel journalists work in conjunction with VisitBritain to maintain the Super Blog. Twitter is used as an integral tool in promoting new posts on the Super Blog; 67% of VisitBritain's tweets linked to an entry on this site. Many of these tweets also contributed to the high level of repeated tweets from VisitBritain, as they attempted to promote these posts several times throughout the day, to avoid the aforementioned problem of tweets becoming 'buried'. Very few posts (6% of Facebook posts and 4% of tweets) were classified as 'general'. DMOs strive to make the most of each and every post by including rich media and helpful information. The frequency, interactivity, and nature of posts all contribute to form the overall social media strategies of the selected DMOs. While some patterns exist, no two DMOs operate their social media accounts in precisely the same way. Other factors also contribute to the overarching social media strategies such as the organisational structure of the DMOs.

DMO organisational structure and social media

Wang et al. (2002) argued that 'since people now can surmount time and space and "be" anywhere, marketing organisations should adapt accordingly and embrace this new space, [virtual communities], as a marketing tool capable of organizing people's knowledge about, and desires for, the places they may wish to visit' (Wang et al., 2002). The way in which DMOs organise their presence in these communities and online space varies significantly from country to country. Moreover, Rogers' (1995, cited in Schegg et al., 2008) innovation model proposes five adopter categories: 'pioneers' (2.5%), 'early adopters' (13.5%), 'early majority' (34%), 'late majority' (34%), and 'laggards' (16%). Consequently, it is expected that DMOs adoption of social media platforms will be varied. Of the seven DMOs in the study with a presence on Facebook and Twitter, six have multiple Twitter and/or Facebook accounts. DMOs often manage a Facebook or Twitter account for each regional office. In some cases, there might be several accounts organised by language. For example, this is the case for the German National Tourism Office. VisitBritain, on the other hand, manages only one account. Tourism Queensland's strategy is similar, as the respondent explained that they have 'weighed all the pros and cons and absolutely feel it is better to keep one central environment that's really well managed... [and the downside is that]... you can't do things specifically'. In contrast, the respondent at VisitBritain suggested that it is possible, and relatively simple, to direct posts on Facebook to users (who 'like' the page) of a specific demographic. For example, a Facebook post could be set to appear only to those who have publicised on Facebook that they speak Portuguese or only those who have set their location to Brazil. Tour Spain operates several social media accounts, and their respondent, explained that the Ministry of Tourism in Madrid is in the process of developing a central strategy to 'bring the offices together' since 'up, every country was doing more or less what they thought they should'.

Which role or job title should be responsible for managing the DMOs social media efforts varies drastically from organisation to organisation. Substantial insight into how the DMO feels about social media can be gained from understanding what roles are associated with managing a social media strategy. Even when organisations are actively trialling

and implementing social media strategies, Gretzel et al. (2006, p. 119) found that their colleagues and superiors are often unsupportive and/or uncomfortable with adopting new Web technologies. The respondent at VisitBritain, confirmed this notion in an effort to 'reflect the organisation's commitment to social media' as the marketing division employs seven people, three of which make up the digital team. However, it is only since the beginning of 2010 that these three titles all included the term 'social media'. These roles include the Head of Digital and Social Media (formerly Head of Digital Media), Social Media Programme Manager (a new role), and Online and Social Media Content Manager (formerly Online Content Manager). While the roles have not changed radically, they have been modified to include 'social media' in the titles. Having the titles incorporate 'social media' was crucial to demonstrating to the rest of VisitBritain how important social media is to the organisation.

Most of the DMOs delegate one employee to be responsible for both the Twitter and Facebook accounts. The French and British DMOs are the only ones to differentiate the roles according to social media platform. The person responsible for managing the French DMO's Twitter account is in the PR department while the person responsible for managing the Facebook account is in charge of the three-person online marketing team. The French DMO respondent referred to the employee who manages Facebook as Community Manager, and explained that this job title was similar to the digital marketing titles at VisitBritain. This is also due to change reflecting a greater dedication to social media. At the time of the interview (July 2011) the respondent already had a greater part of their job consumed with maintaining B2B and B2C relationships via the social media channels. At Tour Spain, social media management and development are not the official responsibilities of any particular position, including positions within the marketing department. Any efforts would 'fall into the lap' of whichever employee is comfortable with and interested in, social media. In this case, because the respondent 'really likes technology', anything that has to do with technology and/or the Internet 'ends up on [their] desk'. In the case of Visit Mexico's London office, it only employs two full-time staff. For that reason, while Visit Mexico 'strongly believe that the Internet, Facebook, and Twitter are fantastic ... you need to have someone who is able to monitor them all the time [because] if the news is not fresh, there is no point in having it' (Visit Mexico respondent). Some DMOs lack of activity can be explained by either the organisation not prioritising social media as a marketing tool, and/or lacking the employees, or the qualified employees, to manage the efforts and the absence of a corporate champion to promote this activity. At the majority of DMOs, the management of social media was seen as a marketing role. The delegation of duties involved with managing social media contributes to the varied strategies of the analysed DMOs. Related to roles and responsibilities is funding, which also differed between the DMOs.

Funding

The majority of DMOs interviewees were unwilling to divulge the specifics of their budget as one would expect in a highly competitive business such as tourism marketing. Yet there were still some common themes associated with the funding of their social media strategies. Clearly DMOs often face challenges with limited financial and human resources which was reinforced by nearly every DMO who expressed that their budgets were small in comparison to other DMOs. Social media is often used a way of dealing with small budgets since when faced with budget cuts organisations naturally 'have to become much more clever in how [they choose] to use their resources' (Tourism Queensland respondent). VisitBritain's

current allocated budget towards social media marketing reiterates the fact that even DMOs actively embracing social media are in the infancy of their strategies. VisitBritain's spend is around £200,000 annually on social media, which accounts for two percent of the £10 million marketing budget. Though each region of the world used to have its own marketing budget, it is now based in London. The majority of their £10 million budget in 2011 will be spent on the 'You're Invited' campaign in various ways such as banner advertising, e-consumer relationship management, and television advertisements. The VisitBritain respondent, however, feels that social media has delivered far more results. When using social media effectively, 'you gain a friend for life, someone you can inspire everyday with original content'. An example of what some of the £200,000 budget has been allocated towards is the successful 'Top 50 UK Places' Facebook application, the respondent's proudest achievement. 'Top 50 UK Places' 'encourages visitors to check in every time they reach a notable British location and write a review of what they find; this information then automatically updates a "Top 50 UK Places" leader board on VisitBritain's LoveUK Facebook Page' (Black, 2011). VisitBritain is the first DMO to use geo-location activity. Geo-location is the technology that enables individuals to use a device, such as mobile phone or computer, to find their location. 'Top 50 UK Places' uses these 'check-ins' to create a top 50 list of attractions. This page gained 250,000 visits in the first couple of weeks, and increased the number of fans of Love UK, VisitBritain's official Facebook page, by 34% (Black, 2011). As the VisitBritain respondent explained, this type of application has 'core longevity', as VisitBritain plans to launch similar applications such as 'Top 50 UK Shows'.

In contrast to VisitBritain, the German National Tourist Board spent about £10,000 on social media in 2010 according to the respondent interviewed. This happened largely because FIFA awarded them with an extra £10,000 in addition to the expected budget and it was felt that this money could best be spent on advertising on Facebook as a pilot project. As the respondent explained, the money was spent to purchase a small advertisement that displayed a poll that asked the question 'Which team will score the most goals at the 2010 FIFA World Cup?' When users voted, it prompted them to become a fan of the German National Tourist Board Facebook page. During the three weeks this advertisement ran, the number of fans for the German Facebook page increased 65.4%, but the respondent admitted that they 'obviously didn't start with that many'. During this period, the advertisement netted 2.9 million impressions, yet only 521 fans 'liked' the Facebook page (a conversion rate of only 0.018%). The respondent acknowledged that this was a very disappointing result given the money spent. A previous advertisement had resulted in 1400 'likes' in 10 days, which the respondent deemed much more successful. The German National Tourism Board was particularly frustrated with the FIFA Facebook campaign because of the technical Facebook billing procedure. Facebook deducts the cost-per-click of the advertising daily, which the respondent noted was 'very hard to administer' for the accounting department. This is one reason why the German Tourist Board is considering outsourcing their social media efforts to an agency that can better organise the accounts and invoice them on a less-frequent basis. In parallel with the German National Tourism organisation, building third-party Facebook applications like 'Top 50 UK Places' is an example of something that is unlikely to be handled in-house at this stage in DMOs social media strategies. To create engaging, creative applications via Facebook requires outsourcing to Facebook application development companies, such as Betapond. This company was contracted by VisitBritain for 'Top 50 UK Places', the same company that Discovery Ireland employed to develop a similar application. Whether or not DMOs will have the necessary funds and technological skills to develop these types of applications in the future is unclear. Even so many DMOs have not yet explored using Facebook applications to create more

dynamic, engaging pages. Some social media strategies simply lack the funds. The Tour Spain respondent explained that the role of social media often becomes the responsibility of one of the many unpaid summer internships where ‘the other offices are small and won’t include a community manager type of person’ anytime soon. In fact, 2011 will mark the first year that any money at all has been allocated towards social media and online networks in the case of Spain. As the respondent suggested, the necessary funds will probably be taken from the television budget since ‘in the past years, every time [Tour Spain] has had to take money from something, it has been TV budget’.

This notion that television commercials are out-dated and ineffective is not uncommon in social media literature. According to Borges (2009, p. 25), the television commercial is ‘one of the most blatant examples of traditional Marketing 1.0’, marketing that he describes as ‘intrusive, interruptive, and a style of one-way shouting at customers’. The Turkish Ministry of Tourism and Culture respondent explained that it only ran one, month-long television spot in the UK once a year, during January and February, due to increased bookings during those months. In contrast, the France Tourism Development Agency had no plans for television commercials. DMOs are looking for other ways to spend their marketing budget more effectively, and social media often stands out as particularly effective.

Audience development and social media

If Facebook were a country, it would be the fourth most populous in the world (Qualman, 2009). Social media reaches people at a scale and speed larger and more quickly than previous communication mediums. Accordingly, the diversity of social media users is enormous and it is evident from this research that DMOs are actively looking to engage two markets through social media- the youth market and businesses and trade professionals. Interviewees suggested that social media is predominantly used by the younger generation. For that reason, many companies are hesitant to participate in social media if their markets are not focused on the youth segment. The respondent from London’s Turkish Office of Culture and Tourism attributed the relative lack of use of social media to that fact that the majority of British visitors to Turkey are ‘older’ and ‘affluent’. However, the number of adults using social networking websites such as Facebook is increasing. The number of adults aged 46–55 years of age who use social networks increased by 30% 2008–2010 (Zickuhr, 2010). During the same time period, usage among those aged 56–64 years of age increased 34% (Zickuhr, 2010). Tourism Queensland recognises that ‘there is a large number of over-50s [on Facebook]’ so that platform ‘offers the breadth [they] are trying to reach’. But the younger generation are the focus of many of the DMOs. In 2010, the French Tourism Board launched a Facebook group called ‘Francophonik’ to promote French music and festivals in the UK (France Tourism office respondent). This campaign was geared wholly towards a younger clientele. Part of the campaign involved partnering with Eurolines, the European coach service. The respondent noted that this particular campaign was so successful (based on Euroline bookings into France) that they repeated the same campaign in 2011.

Similarly, VisitBritain also partnered with student travel companies STA Travel and low-cost airline Air Transat to develop a Facebook application based competition geared towards students. The application was called ‘Unite the Invite’ and launched in February 2011, which randomly matched up pairs of participating Facebook users. The users then had to search for their partner, using the help of their online network, and the winning pair won an exclusive trip for two to London, Edinburgh, Glasgow, Manchester, Cardiff, or Liverpool (Fenrich, 2011). Tourism Queensland also partnered with STA to take

advantage of the youth representation on Facebook by providing working visas to young travellers whose entry point into Australia was via Queensland (Tourism Queensland respondent). Likewise, the respondent from Tour Spain explained that given the majority of their Facebook fans are younger, it guided their decision to sign an agreement with the football team Real Madrid to use sport heavily on the Facebook page. Visit Mexico has also created a campaign for the youth market. In July 2011 they launched a six-month contest called 'I Pic Mexico'. As the Visit Mexico respondent explained, 'I Pic Mexico' encouraged UK tourists who have previously been to Mexico to submit photos of what Mexico means to them. This particular campaign was geared towards a younger audience, and also aimed to increase the followers to Visit Mexico's official Facebook page. Though social media usage is no longer limited to teenagers and students, DMOs are actively employing social media as a means of engaging with these markets.

Social media also carries benefits for B2B relations, not simply B2C relations, as several DMOs pointed out during the interviews. The respondent from the France Tourism Development Agency cited their biggest success in the adoption of social media was an ability to amass a network of travel writers and journalists via the creation of a solely Public Relation Twitter account. This account, @AtoutFranceUKPR used primarily to 'tweet regularly things that are relevant for journalists and also to increase the number of followers ... [on] ... the network' (France Tourism Development Agency respondent). The argument here is that with easier access to relevant information, news, and events, and well-maintained relationships with those in the press, France-related news would be more widely covered in the media. As the respondent explained, with around 5000 travel journalists in the UK, having 1200 on the @AtoutFranceUKPR, created in November 2010 was seen as a major achievement. The German National Tourist office has also found that journalists like Twitter and the respondent attributed this to the fact that 'journalists want to get to information as quickly and as simple as possible without all the glamour; Twitter is simple, quick, and easy for them'.

For VisitBritain, Twitter is a strong public relations marketing tool since the majority of @VisitBritain's followers are domestic visitors. Therefore using twitter for B2B relations proves very effective according to the VisitBritain respondent. Likewise, the respondent from Tourism Queensland also mentioned that in the future, their organisation 'would like to have a trade environment as well as a consumer environment' on one of the social media platforms in the future. They were especially interested in developing better ways to use social media to interact with and inspire travel agents, who in turn could create and utilise their own networks of friends and followers. However, a reason, Tourism Queensland's respondent cited for keeping consumer and business relations separate, was that when it comes to social networks, the way DMOs engage with consumers compared to business and the sort of information each segment is interested in varies drastically. For example, Tourism Queensland has spent a large amount of time getting to know travel bloggers since, 'it's really important if you're talking to people that are talking to the general public with information they want to hear' (Tourism Queensland respondent).

Measuring success in social media

A major concern companies identify when considering whether or not to use social media, or in the early stages of adopting social media strategies is how to measure the return on investment (ROI). According to Fisher (2009, p. 189), the ROI within social media has long been a bone of contention, and seems likely to become ever more so, with the equally lightening spread of both social media use and savage budget cuts. Marketing

professionals ‘are under constant pressure to measure everything they do’, and the success of social media efforts are often extremely difficult to gauge. Hitherto, social media metrics used are broad. They might measure ‘audience size (e.g. number of followers), reach (e.g. viral impact), engagement (e.g. number of comments), sentiment (e.g. consumer response) and outcomes (e.g. resulting traffic, conversions)’ (Schetzina, 2010a). Furthermore, social media often requires qualitative measurements, something with which online marketers are typically neither comfortable nor familiar (Fisher, 2009). This study has identified three key areas in which the DMOs social media efforts are being evaluated: audience size, the degree of consumer engagement, and consumer sentiment.

Most DMOs measure the ROI of their social media strategies by the number of followers/Facebook ‘likes’ and the rate at which those numbers increase. The German National Tourist Board respondent considered measuring ROI impossible because the tourism board is not a commercial company ‘and can’t measure how much money is made, as such’. Still, targets are in place. For 2011, the goal was to gain an additional 4000 fans on Facebook (in order to have 10,000 total fans). Those in the earlier stages of social media adoption are often concerned with amassing as many followers as possible. The German Tourist Board does not measure engagement as the respondent explained, ‘Obviously we can, but we just want fans because that’s what everyone looks at externally’. The head office, regional offices, partners, and even the German government pay careful attention to the Facebook efforts. As they do not have access to other statistics, they are concerned primarily with the scale of audience, i.e. the number of Facebook fans. The France Tourism Development Agency effectiveness is measured by ‘the number of followers and the rate at which the followers increases’ (France Tourism Development Agency respondent). Tourism Queensland, in contrast, decides how to measure their efforts based on targets and goals set by each particular campaign. The respondent for Queensland explained that ‘there’s a whole series of metrics- visits to the website, views of content, increasing the number of Facebook fans, or increasing the number of people on a database who opt to receive information from Tourism Queensland’. Though the respondent mentioned varying metrics of measurement, the majority of those mentioned had to do with numbers and audience size; not how consumers are engaging or their sentiment. This suggests that even organisations comfortable with social media are primarily focused on growing numbers to maximise their reach.

VisitBritain’s Facebook page received 53 million views in 2010 compared 18 million on VisitBritain’s website’s (<http://www.visitbritain.com>) (VisitBritain respondent). Social media has the benefit of being something people interact with regularly, often daily, so whatever the audience size, they view content repeatedly and become very familiar and up-to-date with the brand. This is because the brand meets them at the platform they are using and requires little effort from users to initiate a website visit. Therefore, striving to increase the number of people who engage with this information is an understandable goal. Measuring engagement is also important in order to understand what is successful versus what is futile. According to Tour Spain:

Successful social media is determined by the way people interact, whether or not they respond to things we post. At the moment, because it’s all very new, we are looking more at quality than quantity. Instead of the number of followers, [it’s about whether or not] people ask things . . . do they respond to what we say and in which way. (Tour Spain respondent)

Tour Spain’s tactic is different from many tourism boards since they want to assure good quality content before using other metrics, such as audience size, to evaluate their strategy.

As part of a campaign with student travel agent, STA Travel, Tourism Queensland was solely focused on measuring interaction. The campaign offered free working holiday visas to those whose entry point to Australia was Queensland. One element of the campaign was live chat on Facebook each Friday to answer travel questions. Through this, they were able to measure how many people were engaging and interested in Queensland as a tourism destination. Though Tourism Queensland cited measuring 'the number of followers' as the current method of evaluation social media efforts, the respondent from the France Tourism Development Agency identified engaging with consumers 'at the core of what [needs to be done]'. This was attributed to the need to have direct communication with consumers to support independent UK travellers. As the France Tourism Development Agency respondent explained:

The trade is very important to some products, like the ski market, but when it comes to a summer holiday, most UK travellers to France would book independently. From that point, we are different from other destinations in that we have to adapt our marketing because of that. Social media is a major tool for.

The respondent also noted that, like embracing social media, transitioning from a trade-only strategy to a B2C strategy is quite new and constantly changing. At the core of this is creating content users are interested in and actively engaging with. For many, social media is more about engaging than hard selling. The respondent at VisitBritain is wary about updating Facebook constantly and bombarding consumers with too much information. In contrast, the French Tourism Board respondent argued that one should 'be very careful with hard sales ... to be careful that people don't feel we are selling something too hard ... we are not here to sell directly'. For VisitBritain, this tactic seems to be working, and is converting into more spending. Users who visited the VisitBritain shop (<http://www.visitbritainshop.com>) via clicking a link through Facebook were 28% more likely to purchase something and had 58% larger shopping baskets than consumers driven to the site from elsewhere (VisitBritain respondent).

The degree to which DMOs are measuring success based on the degree of engagement with consumers is limited since research found that the level at which DMOs are actively interacting with their audience is relatively low. A further issue that emerged in interviews was social media's ability to survey consumer sentiment. Consumer sentiment is very closely related to consumer engagement. If consumers were not engaging, then there is no way to measure sentiment. If they are engaging, then how do they feel about the organisation, destination, or experience? Interacting with consumers can also be very beneficial for organisations. Both Tourism Queensland and VisitBritain have examples of consumers helping to strengthen or repair the destination brand especially at a time of crisis.

The Tourism Queensland respondent indicated that during the floods in Queensland in December 2010–January 2011, domestic Facebook fans were able to post pictures and demonstrate that most of Queensland, especially the tourist areas, was 'absolutely fine'. It was a great way to create a community of people talking positively about Queensland at a time when the media was saying 'half of Queensland is underwater', 'it's a nightmare', 'it's a disaster'. 'In an hour', explained the respondent, 'you can watch [on Facebook] what's going on and anecdotally understand how people feel'. Tourism Queensland also measured consumer sentiment during the aforementioned STA travel campaign. They were able to gauge how those interacting on Facebook felt about Queensland as a destination – for example, if they felt it was expensive or if they felt it was a 'must-visit'. In the past, this would have involved measurement through focus groups, which are still

sometimes used, but are always ‘more costly and take more time’. Comments on Love UK are consistently ‘99% positive’, a feature VisitBritain’s respondent appreciated and took pride in. Yet only 13 of 670 total (1.9%) Facebook and Twitter posts during the month of June were related to customer service. Twelve of the thirteen were from the @VisitBritain Twitter account and were responding to criticisms. This suggests that either the DMOs are seldom encountering customer service related issues via social media, or that, more likely, they are not yet using social media to mitigate these problems. The International Federation for IT and Travel and Tourism hosted a workshop at the 2011 World Travel Market to discuss the use of social media for ‘real-time service management’. This sought to demonstrate to organisations how to respond quickly via social media to customer needs. Using this skill to build a strong online community that is loyal and trustworthy is vital to maintaining and supporting positive messages about the destination via social media.

Implications

It is evident that many DMOs understanding of social media is often vague and varied. Very seldom are the rights and wrongs of general marketing rules precisely defined, but rules surrounding social media marketing are even more ambiguous and unclear. This research has provided overarching patterns of usage and a broad picture of the relationship between social media and DMOs. To successfully develop these social media strategies in the future, DMOs should firstly acknowledge the scope and reach social media can have. In fact, the following quotation summarises the relationship between social media and DMOs

Since tourism is traditionally studied and examined in relation to geographic places or space, it is understandable that some tourism marketing organizations lack confidence in and basic understanding of how a virtual community can be used as a marketing tool. However, we cannot afford to ignore this revolutionary changes information technology brings us ... (Wang et al., 2002, p. 416)

DMOs face a variety of complex issues when developing an online presence, especially a social media presence. Many DMOs could improve their position by first acknowledging social media as marketing tool and then by creating a formal, but flexible, strategy. Policy and action should be aligned, though as with any new technology, there should be plenty of room for experimentation. Many studies outline the advantages of social media and networking such as humanising a brand and increased engagement. These also highlight weaknesses identified in this study (e.g. noise and no direct link to sales) alongside the growth of spam. DMOs should pay careful attention to these opportunities and threats to ensure that they are using social media effectively. It is apparent that some DMOs are using social media as they would any other marketing tool, neglecting the full potential of its ability to engage and invoke informal conversation. DMOs need to learn to apply Kaplan and Haenlein’s (2009) list of five key actions to abide by when managing a social media presence: *be active, be interesting, be humble, be informal, and be honest*. These traits differ largely from traditional marketing strategies. Thus, accepting social media as a beneficial tool that is part of an integrated marketing strategy while still understanding its uniqueness as a medium is something with which DMOs struggle.

Figure 7 illustrates a cycle of key steps for successful social media marketing. Though these success factors were originally created in relation to marketing on the Web in general, they are particularly applicable to social media. Engagement and the encouragement of participation are both key in attracting and retaining users. This study has demonstrated that

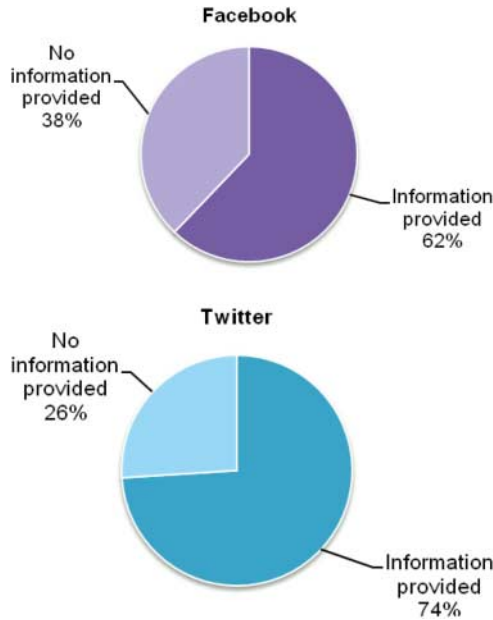


Figure 7. Distribution of Facebook posts and Twitter posts providing information.

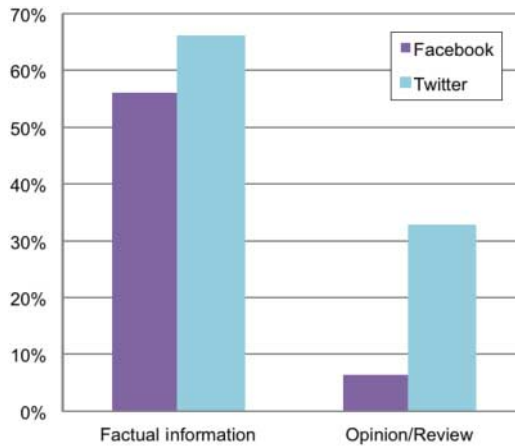


Figure 8. Distribution of type of information provided by Twitter and Facebook posts of the combined DMOs, June 2011.

DMOs need to exhibit more interactive behaviour on their social media platforms. One of the most tangible benefits of social media is that information is publicly available and widely accessible. DMOs need to be up to date and understand how other tourism professionals and organisations are implementing social media strategies to learn from their achievements and mistakes. More importantly, a flexible and innovative approach is fundamental to developing lasting social media success. Recognising social media as a powerful marketing tool and actively improving their social media strategies will pave the way for improvement of DMOs' social media marketing efforts in the future. It is also important to recognise the limitations to this exploratory study.

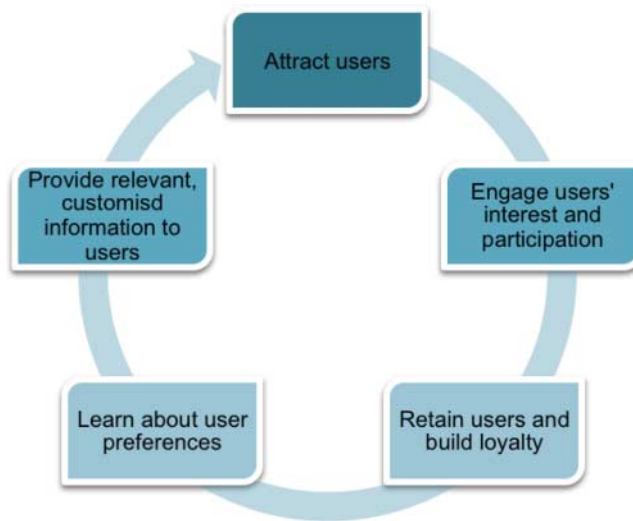


Figure 9. A cycle of key steps for successful social media marketing, adapted from Gretzel et al., 2000:148.

Conclusion

DMOs are at the initial stages of understanding and experimenting with how to use social media to promote their destinations. Many 'struggle to keep pace with the evolution of new technologies ... [and] ... the emergence of new advertising strategies' (Gretzel et al., 2000, p. 146). Both the primary research conducted in this study and the supporting secondary research confirm Gretzel et al.'s (2006) notion that the use of social media among DMOs is still largely experimental. This study has sought to classify, examine, and analyse how top NTOs are utilising social media to engage consumers and market destinations. The results from the content analysis as well as the findings from interviews have illustrated that the social media strategies of top DMOs vary considerably, and with the exception of the efforts of VisitBritain and Tourism Queensland, are largely rudimentary. While this is only a small sample of NTOs, it is examining the world's major destinations and so explores social media usage for destinations with a large proportion of the world's international arrivals. The two cases of VisitBritain and Tourism Queensland offer many examples of best practice which may well offer important lessons for other NTOs starting to enter the world of social media to market their destination.

Three key findings emerge from this research. *Firstly*, the majority of the examined DMOs are not currently utilising social media to their full effectiveness when it comes to the ability to interact and engage with consumers. *Secondly*, social media is still not widely recognised and/or respected as a vital tool in marketing strategies, and thus is frequently underfunded and/or neglected. *Lastly*, DMOs could benefit from becoming even more innovative and creative when it comes to their social media strategies, in order to fully differentiate these efforts from traditional marketing methods. It is also evident that a destination's ranking on tourist arrivals does not dictate a more developed social media strategy, as many less-visited destinations (such as Queensland) are far more active and innovative in their social media efforts. With regards to what factors, if any, contribute to a high level of social media activity, it has been found that perhaps the main factor that dictates an advanced social media strategy is leadership, the simple acknowledgment of social media as a powerful

marketing tool and a champion in the organisation to promote this marketing medium. This is similar to research on ICT innovation adoption elsewhere (Spencer, Buhalis, & Moital, in press). DMOs that have appropriate leadership recognised the capability of social media, such as VisitBritain, have more highly developed social media strategies.

This research confirms that top DMOs ascribe to the view espoused by Wang et al. (2002, p. 416) that 'virtual tourism communities will provide a substantial foundation with which to foster communication among and between travellers and the industry'. Though in different stages of development and with different strategies, the DMOs examined are clearly working to incorporate social media into their marketing strategies. However, the sectors that coalesce to create a community known as the tourism industry seem to be 'reluctant to make full use [of social media] not so much because of active rejection, but because they are unaware of its full potential' (Hay, 2011). Social media is still a relatively new, unknown, and most-importantly, a largely unproven technological phenomenon. As the use of social media as a destination marketing tool becomes more widespread, the marketing strategies of DMOs will likely evolve and improve.

The content analysis reported here would ideally benefit from a longer timeframe, and larger sample size. Were the research to be conducted again, content analysis categories could be expanded accordingly. Repeating the same study in a year's time would most likely yield significantly different results, due to the constantly evolving nature of technology and social media. Additionally, similar research with a larger sample size and time period would provide more comprehensive insights to the use of social media among DMOs. Though the purpose of this study was to explore social media among the top DMOs as a whole, any one of the individual components of this study could be researched as a topic in its own right. For example, further research could be conducted *just* about the degree of interactivity and engagement of DMOs on social media websites. As social media usage among DMOs becomes more prevalent, this type of research will be very beneficial. Lastly, though this study selected DMOs of top international tourism destinations, it would be interesting to conduct a similar study with a different sample. Identifying DMOs with unique, active, and/or successful social media marketing strategies and analysing how they utilise social media could be of particular interest to see if any patterns emerge, or how those DMOs differ from those analysed in this research. Furthermore, this research could be easily applied to other businesses and/or organisations in the tourism sectors, such as hotels, restaurants, attractions or events. Additional studies related to social media and the tourism sector would obviously aid in providing a broad, well-rounded representation of the social media phenomena. Consequently, a more comprehensive typology of strategies to comparatively study social media usage in tourism would emerge.

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